



Summary

After a battle to end the rebellion against King Duncan, army captains Macbeth and Banquo encounter three witches. The witches hail Macbeth as the thane, or earl, of Glamis, the thane of Cawdor, and the future king. Macbeth knows that since SineI has died, he will be thane of Glamis. But he does not yet possess the other titles. Stunned, Macbeth begs the witches to tell him more, but they disappear. Two emissaries arrive, summoning Macbeth to the king. The thane of Cawdor has been sentenced to death for plotting against King Duncan. As a reward for his glories in battle, the king wants to give the title to Macbeth. Although Macbeth is overjoyed, Banquo cautions him and says that evil forces speak part of the truth to lead men to their destruction. Macbeth ignores his friend's advice and begins to think of killing King Duncan, even though the thought of murder is loathsome to him.

Read

Act I, Scene iii

- 1 A heath near Forres.
- 2 *[Thunder. Enter three Witches]*
- 3 FIRST WITCH: Where hast thou been, sister?
- 4 SECOND WITCH: Killing swine.
- 5 THIRD WITCH: Sister, where thou?
- 6 FIRST WITCH: A sailor's wife had chestnuts in her lap,
7 And munch'd, and munch'd, and munch'd:--
8 'Give me,' quoth I:
9 'Aroint thee, witch!' the rump-fed ronyon cries.
10 Her husband's to Aleppo gone, master o' the Tiger:
11 But in a sieve I'll thither sail,
12 And, like a rat without a tail,
13 I'll do, I'll do, and I'll do.

14 SECOND WITCH: I'll give thee a wind.

15 FIRST WITCH: Thou'rt kind.

16 THIRD WITCH: And I another.

17 FIRST WITCH: I myself have all the other,

18 And the very ports they blow,

19 All the quarters that they know

20 I' the shipman's card.

21 I will drain him dry as hay:

22 Sleep shall neither night nor day

23 Hang upon his pent-house lid;

24 He shall live a man forbid:

25 Weary se'nnights nine times nine

26 Shall he dwindle, peak and pine:

27 Though his bark cannot be lost,

28 Yet it shall be tempest-tost.

29 Look what I have.

30 SECOND WITCH: Show me, show me.

31 FIRST WITCH: Here I have a pilot's thumb,

32 Wreck'd as homeward he did come.

33 *[Drum within]*

34 THIRD WITCH: A drum, a drum!

35 Macbeth doth come.

36 ALL: The weird sisters, hand in hand,

37 Posters of the sea and land,

38 Thus do go about, about:

39 Thrice to thine and thrice to mine

40 And thrice again, to make up nine.

41 Peace! the charm's wound up.

42 *Enter MACBETH and BANQUO*

43 MACBETH: So foul and fair a day I have not seen.

44 BANQUO: How far is't call'd to Forres? What are these
45 So wither'd and so wild in their attire,
46 That look not like the inhabitants o' the earth,
47 And yet are on't? Live you? or are you aught
48 That man may question? You seem to understand me,
49 By each at once her chappy finger laying
50 Upon her skinny lips: you should be women,
51 And yet your beards forbid me to interpret
52 That you are so.

53 MACBETH: Speak, if you can: what are you?

54 FIRST WITCH: All hail, Macbeth! hail to thee, thane of Glamis!

55 SECOND WITCH: All hail, Macbeth, hail to thee, thane of Cawdor!

56 THIRD WITCH: All hail, Macbeth, thou shalt be king hereafter!

57 BANQUO: Good sir, why do you start; and seem to fear
58 Things that do sound so fair? I' the name of truth,
59 Are ye fantastical, or that indeed
60 Which outwardly ye show? My noble partner
61 You greet with present grace and great prediction
62 Of noble having and of royal hope,
63 That he seems **rapt** withal: to me you speak not.
64 If you can look into the seeds of time,
65 And say which grain will grow and which will not,
66 Speak then to me, who neither beg nor fear
67 Your favours nor your hate.

68 FIRST WITCH: Hail!

69 SECOND WITCH: Hail!

70 THIRD WITCH: Hail!

71 FIRST WITCH: Lesser than Macbeth, and greater.

72 SECOND WITCH: Not so happy, yet much happier.

73 THIRD WITCH: Thou shalt get kings, though thou be none:

74 So all hail, Macbeth and Banquo!

75 FIRST WITCH: Banquo and Macbeth, all hail!

76 MACBETH: Stay, you imperfect speakers, tell me more:
77 By Sinel's death I know I am thane of Glamis;
78 But how of Cawdor? the thane of Cawdor lives,
79 A prosperous gentleman; and to be king
80 Stands not within the **prospect** of belief,
81 No more than to be Cawdor. Say from whence
82 You owe this strange intelligence, or why
83 Upon this blasted heath you stop our way
84 With such prophetic greeting? Speak, I charge you.

85 *[Witches vanish]*

86 BANQUO: The earth hath bubbles, as the water has,
87 And these are of them. Whither are they vanish'd?

88 MACBETH: Into the air; and what seem'd corporal melted
89 As breath into the wind. Would they had stay'd!

90 BANQUO: Were such things here as we do speak about?
91 Or have we eaten on the insane root
92 That takes the reason prisoner?

93 MACBETH: Your children shall be kings.

94 BANQUO: You shall be king.

95 MACBETH: And thane of Cawdor too: went it not so?

96 BANQUO: To the selfsame tune and words. Who's here?

97 *[Enter ROSS and ANGUS]*

98 ROSS: The king hath happily received, Macbeth,
99 The news of thy success; and when he reads
100 Thy personal venture in the rebels' fight,
101 His wonders and his praises do contend
102 Which should be thine or his: silenced with that,

103 In viewing o'er the rest o' the selfsame day,
104 He finds thee in the stout Norweyan ranks,
105 Nothing afeard of what thyself didst make,
106 Strange images of death. As thick as tale
107 Came post with post; and every one did bear
108 Thy praises in his kingdom's great defence,
109 And pour'd them down before him.

110 ANGUS: We are sent
111 To give thee from our royal master thanks;
112 Only to herald thee into his sight,
113 Not pay thee.

114 ROSS: And, for an earnest of a greater honour,
115 He bade me, from him, call thee thane of Cawdor:
116 In which addition, hail, most worthy thane!
117 For it is thine.

118 BANQUO: What, can the devil speak true?

119 MACBETH: The thane of Cawdor lives: why do you dress me
120 In borrow'd robes?

121 ANGUS: Who was the thane lives yet;
122 But under heavy judgment bears that life
123 Which he deserves to lose. Whether he was combined
124 With those of Norway, or did line the rebel
125 With hidden help and vantage, or that with both
126 He labour'd in his country's wreck, I know not;
127 But treasons capital, confess'd and proved,
128 Have overthrown him.

129 MACBETH: [*Aside*] Glamis, and thane of Cawdor!
130 The greatest is behind.
131 *To ROSS and ANGUS*
132 Thanks for your **pains** .
133 *To BANQUO*
134 Do you not hope your children shall be kings,
135 When those that gave the thane of Cawdor to me
136 Promised no less to them?

137 BANQUO: That trusted home
138 Might yet enkindle you unto the crown,
139 Besides the thane of Cawdor. But 'tis strange:
140 And oftentimes, to win us to our harm,
141 The instruments of darkness tell us truths,
142 Win us with honest trifles, to betray's
143 In deepest consequence.
144 Cousins, a word, I pray you.

145 MACBETH: [*Aside*] Two truths are told,
146 As happy **prologues** to the swelling act
147 Of the imperial theme.--I thank you, gentlemen.
148 [*Aside*]
149 This supernatural soliciting
150 Cannot be ill, cannot be good: if ill,
151 Why hath it given me earnest of success,
152 **Commencing** in a truth? I am thane of Cawdor:
153 If good, why do I yield to that suggestion
154 Whose horrid image doth unfix my hair
155 And make my seated heart knock at my ribs,
156 Against the use of nature? Present fears
157 Are less than horrible imaginings:
158 My thought, whose murder yet is but fantastical,
159 Shakes so my single state of man that function
160 Is smother'd in surmise, and nothing is
161 But what is not.

162 BANQUO: Look, how our partner's rapt.

163 MACBETH: [*Aside*]
164 If chance will have me king, why, chance may crown me,
165 Without my stir.

166 BANQUO: New honors come upon him,
167 Like our strange garments, cleave not to their mould
168 But with the aid of use.

169 MACBETH: [*Aside*]
170 Come what come may,
171 Time and the hour runs through the roughest day.

172 BANQUO: Worthy Macbeth, we stay upon your leisure.

173 MACBETH: Give me your favour: my dull brain was wrought

174 With things forgotten. Kind gentlemen, your pains

175 Are register'd where every day I turn

176 The leaf to read them. Let us toward the king.

177 Think upon what hath chanced, and, at more time,

178 The interim having weigh'd it, let us speak

179 Our free hearts each to other.

180 BANQUO: Very gladly.

181 MACBETH; Till then, enough. Come, friends.

182 *[Exeunt]*

Annotations
